

Q&A

Your Questions, Our Answers

Of Halves And Sixteenths

Q I have a problem with Excel. We manufacture in millimetres, but our customers need measurements in inches. I've used formulas to determine the inches, but when I format a cell for fractions, Excel does not give me the least common denominator. I measure to the level of 1/16 of an inch, but "half an inch" looks like "8/16" in my spreadsheets. How do I get around this?

Inder Kohli

A There are many options in the "Fraction" category of Excel's number formatting. It seems to us that you've chosen the "As sixteenths" option. This, taken literally, means every fraction is rounded to the nearest sixteenth, and is then displayed in sixteenths—as in 8/16 instead of ½.

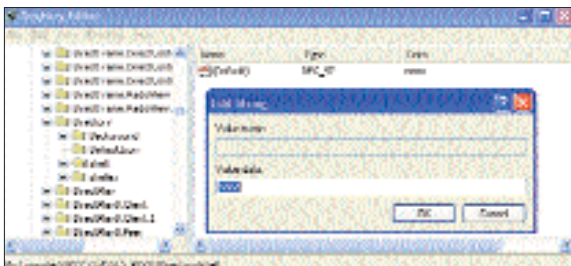
One option is to choose "Up to two digits," in which case you would see 1/2 rather than 8/16. The drawback is that you would also see fractions such as 51/82! You may therefore need to create a new column to display your values in sixteenths. If the base value is in cell A1, the function "**=MROUND(A1/2.54,0.0625)**" would give the value rounded to a sixteenth. After applying the formula, format the cell with "Up to two digits."

Shoo, Doggie!

Q I use Windows XP Professional. Whenever I double-click on any folder in Windows Explorer, the Search Companion pops up. How do I get rid of it?

Prathamesh Mahindre

A You will need to edit the Registry to get rid of the Search Companion. But we'd like to warn you that you should proceed only if you're familiar with editing the Registry: one wrong step could render Windows unbootable.



Modify Registry key to open folder on double-click

In the Registry Editor, navigate to "HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT\Directory\shell", and locate the "Default" entry in the right pane. Click "Modify" to change the value, and enter "none" in the "File" data box. Click OK and exit the Registry Editor. That should make the little dog go away!

Squish!

Q I have Windows XP installed on my computer—a Pentium 4 2.4 GHz with 512 MB of RAM and an 80 GB hard drive. I have a broadband connection. I suspect that a virus has infected my computer. I find small executable files in each folder with their names as that of the root folder. What can I do?

Kalyani Guhathakur

A Your computer has been infected by W32.Traxg@mm, which is a mass-mailing worm that sends itself to all addresses in the Microsoft Outlook address book. This is not a high-risk worm—all it does is send copies of itself to various e-mail recipients. Removal of the worm is very easy—just follow these steps.

1. Install an anti-virus and update the virus definitions from the vendor's Web site.

2. Disable System Restore. To do this, go to **Control Panel > System > System Restore**, and tick the box next to "Turn off System Restore on all drives". Click OK.

3. Restart the computer in Safe Mode.

4. Run a full system scan and delete all the infected files detected during the scan.

5. Open the Registry Editor. Navigate to "HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run". In the right pane, delete "TempCom" = "%WinDir%\Fonts\<randomname>.com", where "random-name" can be any random file name. Exit the Registry Editor and restart the computer in normal mode.

6. You may also want to restore the default settings of Windows Explorer that were changed by the worm. To do this, start Windows Explorer, go to **Tools > Folder Options > View**, and click the Restore Defaults button. Click OK and close Windows Explorer.

Seeing Double

Q I use Windows XP Home SP1. Add or Remove Programs displays two entries for some programs I've installed. How do I correct this?

Anil Kumar Sahoo

A Sometimes, when you uninstall a program and install a higher version, or when you install a newer version of a program over an older version, the entries of the old program are left in the Add or Remove Programs applet. This happens because some programs do not correctly remove the Registry entries of the uninstall string for the program while being uninstalled or upgraded.

To correct this problem, download and install X-Setup Pro from www.x-setup.net. This is a system configuration and tweaking utility. Launch the program and navigate to **System >**